Northeast Asia.[19] Worries over Chinese encroachment in the East China Sea, not to mention North Korea's nuclear program, are now a regular part of the national discourse, and an increasingly assertive posture toward the North Korean threat in particular has been adopted by successive Japanese governments. Over the past decade in particular, Tokyo has invested in antimissile defenses, placed orders for advanced fighter aircraft, and slowly added capabilities to project power in Asia, including through refueling tankers for fighters and building two new, large helicopter carriers, and the country has recently announced plans for its first aircraft carrier since World War II.[20]

Yet even with a greater awareness of foreign threats, Japan's position in the world remains a contested issue in domestic politics, as does the larger question of Japanese nationalism and patriotism. A 2015 international Gallup poll, for example, showed that only 11 percent of Japanese would be willing to fight for their country.[21] Granting that most Japanese share an instinctive desire to retain some boundaries against the rest of the world, the debate then is over the degree to which Japan should engage so as not to put at risk its natural separateness. It is here that Prime Minister Shinzo Abe's foreign policies are so controversial.

Abe returned to office in late 2012, determined to pick up from where he ignominiously left off in 2007. He quickly dusted off plans to increase the military budget, form a National Security Secretariat, end the restrictions on arms exports and defense industry cooperation, and pursue enhanced relations with a number of strategic countries, including India and Australia. Most notably, he submitted to the Diet a bill to allow for the exercise of collective self-defense, so as to deepen security cooperation with the United States and other potential partners. At nearly the same time, Abe was negotiating with the Obama administration on a set of revised guidelines for the US-Japan Alliance, designed to enhance security cooperation and embrace new areas, such as cyber and space.

From the beginning, both the security bill and the revised guidelines drew heavy criticism from the opposition party and domestic groups.